

BEACHES AND SPITS



CRESCENT BEACH

Waves breaking at an angle toss stones and sand grains sideways. This process, called longshore drift, gradually extends the beach down to the next headland. It often creates beautiful crescent beaches like the famous Copacabana Beach in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil.



LONG BEACH

If there is no headland farther down the shore, longshore drift keeps moving the beach material along the coast. This creates immensely long beaches, like this one on the south coast of England. The beach is often backed by lagoons cut off from the open sea.



SPITS

A long beach may extend into open water to form a spit. The spit keeps growing across the river mouth as more beach material is moved down the coast by longshore drift. Shown here is the Clatsop Spit in Oregon. It stretches 2 miles (4 km) across the river mouth.



MUDFLATS ►
Mud particles carried off the land in rivers are dropped when the river current meets the sea, and they settle to form banks of fine, sticky, airless mud. These may extend to the sea to create a river delta, with several channels carrying sediments over its surface, as seen here in this satellite image of the Ganges Delta in Bangladesh.

